

Page Breaks

Written by

Andy Example

Andy Example
12 Example Road
Exometown EX1 2AB
andy@example.com
555 0100

FADE IN:

INT. TOWN HALL - NIGHT

The hall smells of floor polish and wet coats. Forty folding chairs face a stage that is really just four tables pushed together under a velvet curtain the colour of old blood.

Every chair is taken. People stand along the back wall with their arms folded, steam rising off their shoulders. Somebody has brought a thermos and is pouring tea into its lid with great care.

On the stage, behind a card that says CHAIR, sits COUNCILLOR EDIE MARSH (60s, reading glasses on a chain, a voice built for weather warnings). She taps the microphone. It howls. Everybody winces.

To her left, at a card that says SECRETARY, sits TOM PELL (30s), taking minutes in a notebook that already has three pages of doodles in it.

EDIE

Order. Order, please. I know it is late and I know it is raining and I know some of you came here straight from the pub.

A cheer from the back. Edie ignores it.

EDIE (CONT'D)

One item on the agenda tonight. The lighthouse.

A murmur runs through the room like wind through a hedge.

TOM

(reading from his notes)

The motion is to sell the lighthouse to the gentleman from the city for one point two million pounds.

At the back, a tall, soaked woman pushes off the wall: NELL ASHBY (40s), the last lighthouse keeper on this coast, though the light has been automatic for twenty years.

NELL

Can I say something?

EDIE

You can say something in the time set aside for public comment, Nell,
(MORE)

EDIE (CONT'D)

which is three minutes, which Tom
is timing.

Tom holds up a kitchen timer shaped like an egg. He twists
it. It ticks.

NELL

My grandfather kept that light. His
father kept it before him. Every
night for a hundred and forty years
somebody from my family climbed
those stairs, all one hundred and
twelve of them, and lit the lamp,
and trimmed it, and sat up with it
through gales that took the roofs
off half this town. Nobody paid us
much. Nobody thanked us at all. And
when the ships stopped needing us,
we kept climbing anyway, because a
light that nobody keeps is just a
machine, and a machine doesn't care
who it saves. You want to sell it
to a man who will put a hot tub on
the gallery and rent it to people
who have never once been afraid of
the sea. Fine. Sell it. But do not
stand up here and tell me it is
only a building. It is the reason
half of you have grandparents at
all. It is the reason your boats
came home. It is the last thing on
this coast that ever stayed awake
for anybody, and you are going to
let it go for a number that will be
spent on a roundabout by Christmas.

The egg timer rings. Nobody moves to stop it. It rings and
rings until Tom, embarrassed, smothers it under his
notebook.

EDIE

(quietly)

Thank you, Nell.

People begin to file out.

Tom closes his notebook.

Eddie takes off her glasses and rubs her eyes.

The thermos man screws the lid back on his thermos.

EXT. TOWN HALL - CONTINUOUS

Rain. Nell comes out alone and stands under the porch light, breathing hard. Across the bay, the lighthouse turns its slow white eye across the water, once, twice, three times.

She watches it until the door opens behind her.

THE END